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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

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MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telcon with French President Chirac (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
President Chirac
Interpreter: Carol Wolter
Notetakers: Alexander Vershbow, Nelson Drew,
Katherine O'Loughlin

DATE, TIME July 19, 1995
AND PLACE: 8:20 - 9:00 a.m.

President Chirac: Hello Bill. (U)

The President: Hello Jacques. How are you? (U)

President Chirac: Fine and you? Do you mind if we use an interpreter. It will be easier. (U)

The President: That will be fine. I would like to talk about where we are here on the Bosnia question. I agree with you that the status quo is clearly no longer tolerable. You have done tremendous service in rallying support in Europe for stronger action. I agree with you that we need to draw the line at Gorazde. The issue is how, finding the best way to do this militarily. (C)

Our military advisors here feel strongly the best thing is to be able to bring air power to bear in a decisive manner and not in a timid way as has been done lately. We propose issuing a clear warning to Bosnian Serbs that any attack on Gorazde or Sarajevo will be met by a sustained air campaign that will actually cripple their military capability. Now if we do this we must all be prepared to follow through, without wavering. Of course, we should begin now, or soon, to reduce the exposure of UN personnel to keep them from being taken hostage. (C)

Our planners believe the first targets would have to be a full range of Bosnian Serb air defense capabilities: SAMs, anti-aircraft artillery, radar and command centers. They also believe once air defenses are neutralized, we would be able to mount a

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major air campaign against any Bosnian Serb forces attacking Gorazde or Sarajevo or any military targets elsewhere. But to do this and make it work we would have to have some changes. The dual key could not be maintained in its present form. Of course local ground commanders could retain a voice in close air support and close-proximity airstrikes directly affecting their troops. But there could be no UN political veto over individual missions. Also current restrictions regarding strict proportionality would also have to be removed. We would have to have the ability to strike strategic targets throughout Bosnia, and that would be a big deterrent to them doing anything to UN forces. Now, I have talked to John Major yet, but Warren Christopher met with Rifkind last night urging the British to get on board with this. In order to get there, we will also need to get other Allies and Boutros Ghali on board. (C)

In addition to supporting an effective Bosnian defense of Gorazde, it is important to open secure land access routes to Sarajevo. I believe this should be the most pressing mission for the RRF. (C)

With regard to the suggestion you made last week regarding deploying 1,000 of your troops to Gorazde -- I would like to talk to you about that for a few minutes. Our military people believe that since the primary threat to Gorazde is from artillery shells, adding 1,000 troops might increase deterrence but it would not materially change the military balance, and might create an increased problem of resupply and reinforcement. They also say that if we were to do it, we have to take pre-emptive action against air defenses. Otherwise French troops and our helicopters will be sitting ducks and the likelihood that we will lose helicopters with your troops on board is quite strong. (C)

I agree with you that we cannot abandon Gorazde, but we must make certain we have what are the most effective means we can take to defend it. I know in sending another 1,000 troops -- especially French troops -- it may have a psychological effect on the Serbs. But in sending in troops our military people believe (and I agree with them) that there would be considerable risks and that it wouldn't change the military balance in Gorazde. At any rate, I think it's imperative that you and I work together between now and Friday. We have to make sure we have a common approach that together we can sell to John Major. I'm sure Kohl will support us if we are in this together. We can't let this go on. It will mean disaster for Bosnia and the West if it happens. (C)

Let me make one more point, and then I'd like to listen to you. In the two years I have labored with this problem, since before you became President, the only thing that has made things better has been a clear and credible threat that the UN will let NATO

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take strong air action. It has always bought us time for the political process. It got the peace process back on track, allowed the creation of the safe areas, the end of the shelling of Sarajevo, the weapons collection points, etc. It has worked. But when the UN has moved away from a position of strength, the Serbs have taken advantage. I believe this will work if we stay together behind it. (C)

President Chirac: Bill, I understand your position very well, but it would be difficult to implement. If there were no troops on the ground it would be the right approach; but we do have troops there and airstrikes may be too dangerous. The Serbs are very tough people. The minute we attack, and we're not sure if the strikes will be effective, they will retaliate by taking soldiers hostage or attacking with the massive artillery they have. The plan proposed by the U.S. military presupposes the withdrawal of UNPROFOR but we have UN troops everywhere there. If we want to adopt it, we have to regroup or extract our forces. It will be a long and difficult procedure and this presupposes that the U.S. is in a war situation with Serbia. It will be difficult to implement and I believe John Major will never accept this. (C)

If you want to do something to the Serbs using airstrikes, first we have to withdraw the blue helmets...It could be a good solution, but time is necessary to implement the solution. This would mean the loss of Gorazde and probably Sarajevo. This is the reason we made a compromise solution that in any case would maintain the rights of the UN in Gorazde and, in other words, guarantee the safety of 60,000 Muslims in Gorazde. In order to do this, we think 1,000 men would be enough. I don't mean blue helmets, but real soldiers with real equipment. I realize the problem is transporting them to Gorazde, and there only U.S. intervention makes the transport possible, using air power to open a corridor to ensure the safety of the helicopters. If we adopt airstrikes as the objective, it's a solution but not an immediate solution. I think Gorazde will have fallen by then. This is our position -- the least bad solution would be to defend Gorazde. (C)

The President: Let me comment on the points you have made. First, with any solution, greater action carries a risk of greater danger. If we put 1,000 French troops in Gorazde as part of a real defense of the city, that would also go beyond the UN mandate and past what the British said they would do. It also would increase the risk of hostage taking throughout the country. If French troops were killed in the actual defense of Gorazde, I believe we would have to take retaliatory action. I do not agree with you if we carry out the plan for air power, we have to withdraw UN troops. But we would have to concentrate them in

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Gorazde, Sarajevo and Central Bosnia in places the Government controls. (S)

President Chirac: Bill, the minute our troops start to move, the Serbs will understand the maneuver and grab people. (S)

The President: I understand the practical problems. You said that if we issue the threat, it amounts to the U.S. being willing to go to war with Serbia. If you go back to when we got the agreement to establish the safe areas and put all Serb heavy artillery in collection areas, this happened only because two things occurred at the same time: we threatened strong air action through NATO, and the Russians told the Serbs that they had to do this and get back to the negotiations. They thought that the air action would be disproportionate, not selectively calibrated to take out one or two guns or a single tank here or there. (S)

Let me say another thing with regard to your proposal. It seems to me that if we work with you and deploy your forces and the Serbs shoot down one helicopter, or if we redeploy forces and one of your soldiers is killed, even by distant shelling, that we would have to take the most effective retaliatory action, which is from the air. We may have to do some in advance to create a security corridor for the helicopters. We will have to carry out our option one way or another. Before you became President, our UN and NATO allies agreed on two previous occasions that an air threat is the only way to save the UN mission without involving NATO troops on the ground in combat. (S)

Let me say two other things and then I will listen. I want to reemphasize that this will not mean war on the Serbs if they don't attack. There will be no air action if Gorazde is not hit and Sarajevo is not shelled. We simply will be reestablishing the weapons exclusion zones that have eroded. I have also been handed a note that the British are prepared to keep their 300 troops in Gorazde under this proposal and not withdraw. (S)

Jacques, I have to give a speech today, but after that I will be working on this for the next 48 hours. Perhaps you would like to talk to your military people some more. You have done a tremendous job putting unity into the Allied effort, but we want something that works. We don't want to collapse the UN mission. Those in Congress who say otherwise are wrong. Based on my experience over the past two years, this will work. It is our best chance, particularly if coupled with a new diplomatic initiative along the lines you have already discussed with me. (S)

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President Chirac: O.K. Well, I don't mind talking to the experts Bill, but with troops scattered throughout territory, airstrikes are extraordinarily dangerous for those who are there. The difference between one year ago is that the Serbs have recovered all their artillery and are prepared to fight. They have the feeling they can win. I am convinced that they have the full support of Milosevic and the Belgrade Serbs. (X)

I have one question. Will Congress succeed in lifting the arms embargo? (X)

The President: They likely will vote to lift it in some form. I will veto it and believe I can sustain the veto if, and only if, all of us are working on an alternate program with some chance of success. Otherwise I'm afraid that if they voted today, they would override the veto. They believe the UN has failed and the embargo denies the Bosnian Government the ability to defend themselves. (X)

Let me ask two questions. First, several months ago when the safe areas were worked out for the first time, the Serbs had artillery and they gave it up; and I still believe Milosevic would like some relief from sanctions. If we put 1,000 French troops in Gorazde and the Serbs attack the city what will the French do? Will they shoot back? (X)

President Chirac: Of course, naturally. These won't be "blue helmets." Real soldiers will be sent. (X)

The President: All right, but if that happens, then you can argue that that is as much a change in the UN mission as dropping bombs. Mladic is a smart man. If you repel him, he'll take action elsewhere. He will take Ukrainians or Canadians hostage. If we fly you in there and they take action, shoot down a helicopter, we both have to take action. So please think it through. Either our option or yours, or the two of them in combination, will increase the risk they will take UN peacekeepers hostage. But we have to protect Gorazde. The question is the best way to do it. Either course runs the risk of hostages. We have never in the past had to take extreme action when they really thought we would follow through, and not just hit one or two tanks. We got Gorazde, Srebrenica, the safe areas. Somehow, we have to recreate those conditions. We only have a few months ago get a peace agreement. We can't keep doing this for another three or four more years. We have to create the environment in which we can push for a diplomatic solution. (X)

President Chirac: Yes, I understand. But I am pretty sure that all of the people on the ground will ask to regroup before airstrikes and this will take time. Gorazde will be taken in 10

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days, and after that Sarajevo. We need time for this strategy. Let's ask our Chiefs of Staff. (S)

The President: I understand. I really want to work on this with you. Here's the question: Ask your staff if there is a greater likelihood of hostage taking if air power is used as opposed to the chance hostages will be taken if the French fight back and kill a lot of Serbs. Our expectation is that Mladic is very smart and will go elsewhere. He works the country as one big piece. If they shoot down a helicopter and kill Frenchmen, we have to strike hard. Talk to your people. I think we can sell our proposal to the Brits. They don't want to pull out. (S)

President Chirac: There are also others beyond us -- Canadians and Ukrainians. (S)

The President: I know. There's a lot of work to do. We have to discuss it with Canada. We have a close relationship with the Ukrainians. We also need to work with Russia. I think I can convince Yeltsin to go along. (S)

President Chirac: I don't think Yeltsin is ready to do anything because of his domestic political situation. (S)

The President: We don't want to do anything that would imperil him. But last time, Yeltsin went to Milosevic saying you can't do this to yourself or me, and you need to stop the attacks. He was helpful because he didn't want us to use force to protect these areas. We need to explore whether he is in the position to do anything. (S)

President Chirac: Let's get back in touch within 48 hours. (S)

The President: Maybe we should talk in 24 hours. We cannot afford to go to the London meeting and have it be a disaster. (S)

President Chirac: I agree completely, but we must get in touch with the others. (S)

The President: I have talked to Chretien and Kohl, but not yet to the Ukrainians, Dutch or Yeltsin. You and I need to agree on a strategy, work together, and sell it to Major and the others. We must get close on an agreement. (S)

President Chirac: Okay, thank you very much. (U)

The President: Good-bye. (U)

-- End of Conversation --

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